DECISION ANALYSIS × ETHICS

Decision Analysis & Ethics

How should we decide what we ought to do?

A demonstration of moral philosophy at work

Philippe Alexis philippe@nodiamonds.com



The basic Decision Analysis question

A good decision is not the same as a good outcome.

You can make a good decision and get unlucky, or make a bad decision and get lucky.

Decision Analysis asks whether the choice made sense given what you wanted, what you knew, and what might happen.

> **Given what I want, what I know, and what might happen — what should I do?**

A disciplined way to move from a messy choice to a reasoned one.

DA works from the inputs it is given

In many decisions, that is perfectly fine.

SHARED OBJECTIVE

INCREASE REVENUE

REDUCE WAITING TIME

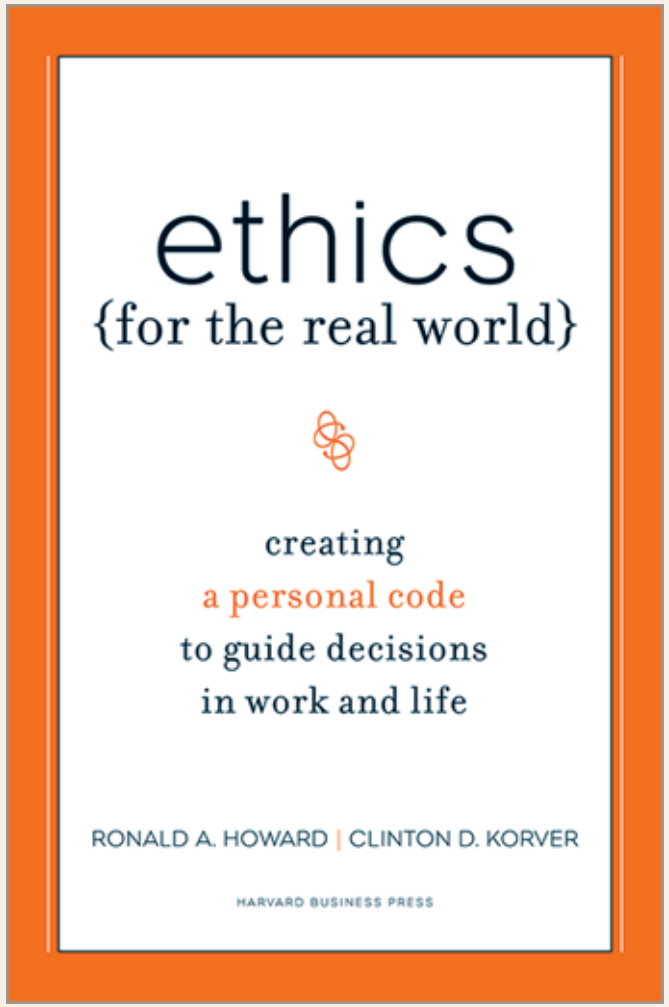
IMPROVE RELIABILITY

Given a shared objective, Decision Analysis can get to work.

> DA can test uncertainty and coherence. It does not, by itself, provide a moral standard for whether an objective or alternative is permissible.

That limitation matters only when the moral acceptability of the frame becomes a question.

Decision Ethics



Ronald A. Howard & Clinton D. Korver

Ethics for the Real World (2008)

WHAT I'LL CALL "DECISION ETHICS"

> **Ethical reflection can help determine which alternatives may properly enter the analysis in the first place.**

Let's see how that works in a case.

Virginia, 1785

FICTIONAL CASE · REAL HISTORICAL SETTING

Imagine a Virginia plantation owner who thinks of himself as a good man.

THE PLANTER

Inherited an estate, debts,
and enslaved people.

His son has been admitted to Harvard.
Tuition is due in two weeks.

THE DECISION

Most readily saleable asset:

An enslaved carpenter

Father of three children on the plantation.

> **Sell him to pay the tuition?**

The point is to watch a morally serious person reason from inside his own world.

Frame #1: “How can I pay my son’s tuition?”

Borrow more

Debt / interest

Sell land

Not liquid; long-term uncertainty

Cut expenses

Reduce household spending

Sell the man

Raises cash quickly

DA RESULT

SELL THE MAN

Given this frame, this may be the best choice.

Without anything challenging the frame, the decision could end here.

This is what the planter could have done before anything disturbed his original frame.

The DA answer now troubles him

WHAT CHANGED?

He has recently read

Montesquieu's The Spirit of the Laws

He now sees the sale as separating a father from his wife and children.

The book does not give him the answer. It changes what he notices.

INNER VOICE

"Something about this is wrong."

What is this unease pointing toward?

ONE POSSIBLE FORMULATION

I should not separate families or inflict serious harm without compelling reason.

Making the concern explicit lets him examine it, compare it with other commitments, and ask whether it should constrain action.

The inner voice signals a problem; it does not uniquely determine the principle.

The facts stay the same. The question changes.

BEFORE

How can I pay my son’s tuition?

AFTER

May I inflict this harm on this family in order to fulfill my obligation to my son?

The alternatives did not change. The kind of decision did.

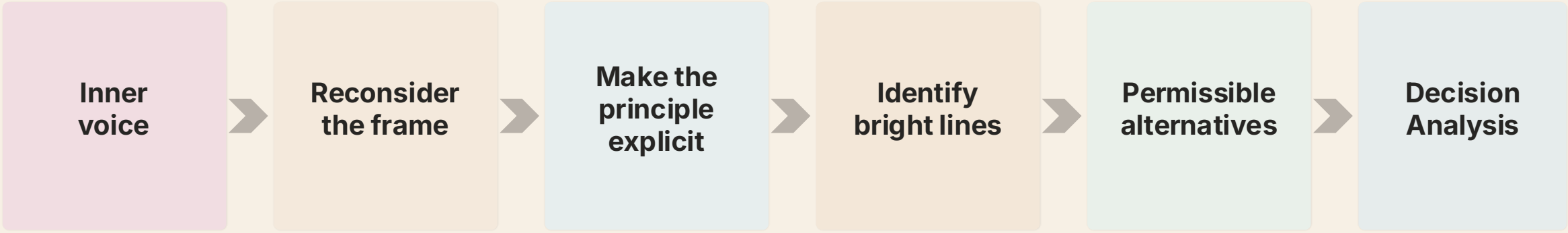
Some principles are boundaries, not just costs

> I should not destroy another family for the benefit of my own.

Borrow more	Sell land	Cut expenses	Sell the man
			REMOVED

If the principle is a bright line, the sale is not given a very bad score. It is removed from the permissible set.

Decision Ethics, so far



The key move: ethics constrains which actions count as permissible; DA then helps choose carefully among the remaining alternatives.

Two serious principles. Opposite directions.

PRINCIPLE A

Do not destroy another family for the benefit of your own.

→ Do not sell

PRINCIPLE B

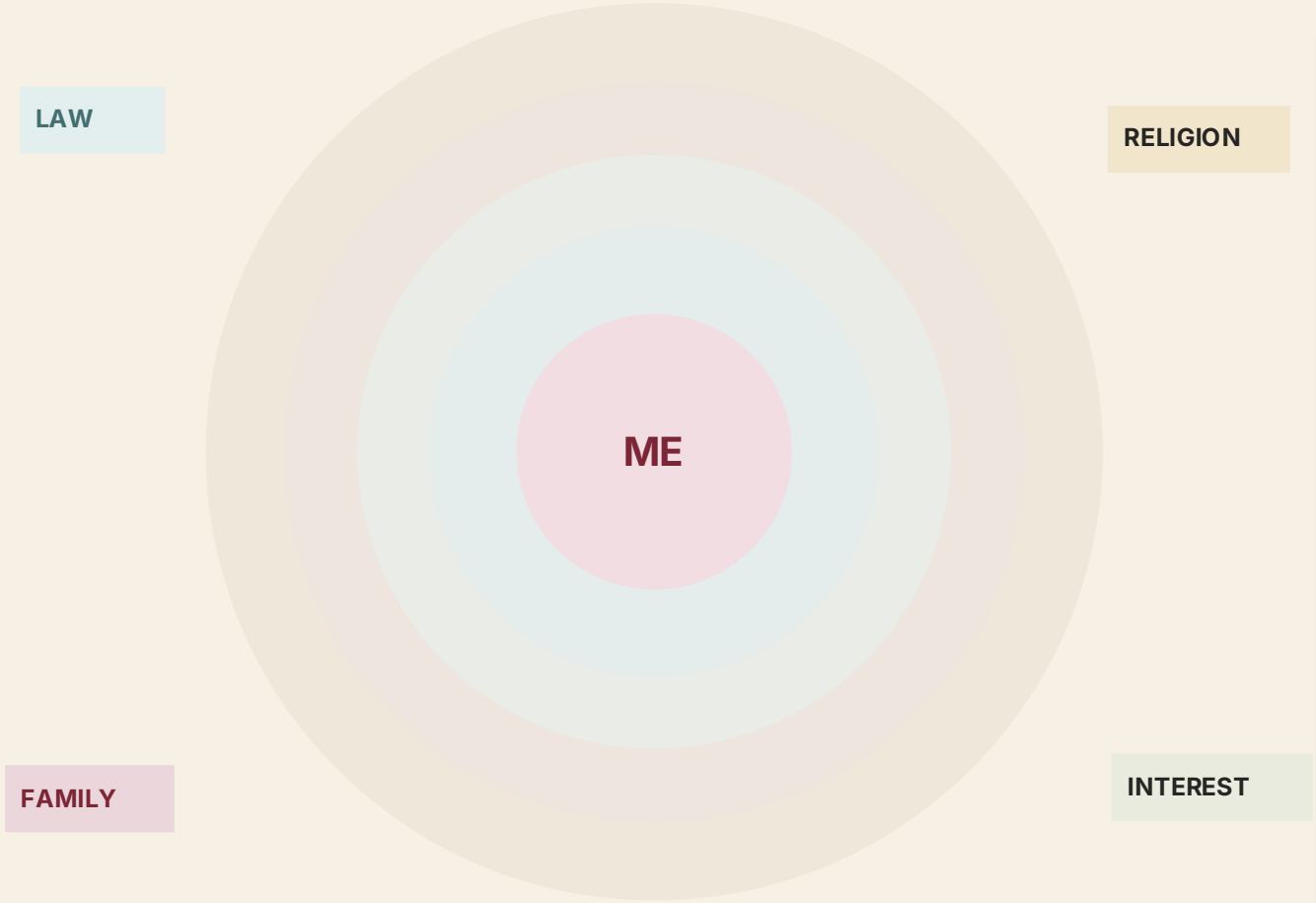
Do not sacrifice your child's future when you possess a lawful means to provide for it.

→ Sell

Which principle deserves priority?

This is now an evaluation problem, not merely a framing problem.

But who is evaluating the principles?



The same person who frames the decision also evaluates the principles that challenge the frame.

LAW	RELIGION
FAMILY	ECONOMIC INTEREST
HABIT	HISTORY

What if the judge has inherited the very assumptions that need to be questioned?

Why Yoga here?

We could import another ethical theory to rank the principles.

What makes Yoga especially interesting at this point is that it puts a second problem near the center of ethical inquiry:

> **How should we examine the person who framed the problem and is now judging the principles?**

Not simply another code to import — a method for examining the chooser as well as the choice.

Sovereignty: the ethical ideal

Sovereignty is an ideal to be devoted to — expressed in two essential traits.

SELF-GOVERNANCE

One's judgments and actions are genuinely one's own.

Not simply products of affliction, conditioning, habit, interest, or authority.

UNCONSERVATISM

Actively test what you have inherited or previously settled on.

Do not treat your existing worldview as the default that must be defended.

How does Yoga apply to the case?

The point is not to replace one principle with another. It is to examine the standpoint from which the principles and frame arose.

SELF-GOVERNANCE ASKS

> **Why did "sell another person" appear as an ordinary alternative in the first place?**

What assumptions are shaping my judgment?

UNCONSERVATISM ASKS

Actively test the inherited frame:

What if ownership does not give me the right to sell him?

What if his obligations to his family matter as much as mine?

> **Sovereignty is not only mine: ethical inquiry must also recognize the agency of the people my decisions affect.**

Ahiṃsā: from non-harm to disrupting harm

Ahiṃsā is often translated as non-harm. In the account used here, it is more active:

Disrupt harm.

Why? Because harm can undermine another person's ability to govern their own life.

IN THE CASE

Slavery claims control over

- MOVEMENT
- LABOR
- FAMILY
- FUTURE

WHAT CHANGES?

The issue is no longer only the suffering caused by this sale.

Slavery itself is a practice of domination that denies another person's agency.

The ethical task shifts from minimizing harm in one transaction to questioning — and, where possible, disrupting — the practice that makes the transaction possible.

What happens to the two principles now?

DECISION ETHICS

Principle A

Do not destroy another family for the benefit of your own.

Principle B

Do not sacrifice your child's future when you possess a lawful means to provide for it.

Both still express serious concerns.

POSSIBLE RESOLUTION

1 "Lawful" is not enough to make domination permissible.

→ Selling the man leaves the permissible set.

2 The duty to his son can remain.

→ He must pursue it through permissible alternatives — or reconsider the plan.

BACK TO DA

- Borrow more
- Sell land
- Cut expenses
- **Reconsider plans**

Decision Analysis can now do what it does well: choose among the remaining alternatives.

Decision Ethics → examine the principles and the chooser → better frame → permissible alternatives → Decision Analysis

OUR 1785?

The Virginia case seems easy to us from 250 years away.

What seems morally ordinary to us because it is...

LEGAL?

FAMILIAR?

CONVENIENT?

SOCIALLY ACCEPTED?

Eating animals?

The comparison does not settle the answer. It gives us a present-day case on which to use the same method.

What will people 250 years from now find obvious that we cannot see?